

Gender and maturity for professional choice

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ABSTRACT

In contemporary Brazilian society, most people who seek professional guidance are in adolescence, a period marked by intense biopsychosocial transformations. Adolescents generally present themselves at a delicate moment in their personal trajectory and may present greater or lesser maturity to make their occupational choice. In view of these considerations, the present study aimed to discuss the influence of gender on the professional maturity of adolescents. To complement this discussion, some initial data from a study involving 100 high school students (of both genders) from public and private schools located in Minas Gerais/Brazil will be presented. For data collection, a questionnaire developed specifically for this study and the Maturity Scale for Professional Choice (EMEP) were used. The results showed that there is a significant difference in some dimensions of maturity for professional choice according to the respondent's gender. Female participants were more responsible and independent, as they reported being less influenced by other people's opinions to make this decision. However, male subjects showed greater knowledge of the educational and economic reality of the job market. The results obtained may serve as subsidies for the construction of more effective interventions in professional guidance, which aim to stimulate the development of maturity in the process of professional choice.

Keywords: Gender, Professional Orientation, Adolescence.

■ INTRODUCTION

In contemporary Brazilian society, generally, those who seek the Vocational Guidance service are in their late teens, a moment marked by many physical and psychological transformations and consolidation of aspects of their identity. Thus, the individual is, in general, at a delicate moment in his personal trajectory in the search for growth and development and may present greater or lesser maturity to make his occupational choice (Levenfus & Soares, 2010).

In terms of professional development, adolescence is characterized as a stage of exploring both the internal world and personal characteristics, as well as the occupational reality and present and future responsibilities that arise in terms of studies and work. According to Neiva (1999), to reach maturity for the professional choice, it is necessary for the individual to develop certain attitudes (determination, independence and responsibility) and acquire knowledge (self-knowledge and knowledge about the educational and socioprofessional reality).

In this way, the greater the individual comes into contact with such aspects and manages to ponder them in search of a professional definition, the more he develops his maturity for this decision making. On the other hand, the less the individual has developed such attitudes and knowledge, the lower their maturity for professional choice (Neiva, 2003). As indicated by Lobato (2001):

Professional choice presupposes a decision-making process of self-awareness and the possibility of carrying out a project imagining oneself fulfilling a social and occupational role. It is necessary, therefore, to differentiate the personal project and the own identity of the projects that others do for people, analyzing, including the influences received by the media on professions notoriously considered “masculine” and “feminine”. (Lobato, 2001: 10).

However, for adolescents, choosing is not an easy task, as many factors are at play at this stage of the individual's life. Choosing what one wants to be in the future implies recognizing who one “was” and who one “is” now, realizing the influences experienced since childhood. For Lobato (2001), what is expected for the future is loaded with affections, hopes, fears and insecurities, not only of the person himself but also of the closest people, such as parents, grandparents, siblings, and friends.

Within this context, the present work, in addition to a theoretical reflection on the subject, aims to present the initial data of an ongoing study, whose purpose is to identify and discuss the influence of the gender category on the professional maturity of individuals and the consequent choice of professional. The participants are teenagers in the last year of high school, students from public schools and the private sphere from two municipalities in Minas Gerais/Brazil. In that study, a semistructured interview script - developed specifically for this purpose - and the application of the Maturity Scale for Professional Choice (EMEP)

were used as instruments for data collection. Seeking to fulfill the proposed objectives, the young students were organized into two groups separated by gender.

The following text is structured to present, first, some definitions and characteristics of the maturity process in professional choice. It was also described how gender issues are related to the development of professional/occupational identity. Finally, some initial considerations of a study still in progress will be presented that seeks to identify and understand the various factors associated with gender differences in the professional choice process, seeking to characterize issues that permeate the lives of Brazilian adolescents.

The study of this theme is justified since the discussions on the various aspects related to the categories of gender and maturity in professional choice can allow professionals in professional guidance to reflect on planning and appropriate action in this field. Thus, it is essential that the work of vocational advisors consider the interaction of the concepts of professional maturity and gender differences, especially in the phase marked by the end of high school and the future insertion of young people into the professional world.

BRIEF HISTORY OF THE MATURITY CONCEPT FOR PROFESSIONAL CHOICE

The original concept of vocational maturity was proposed by the American psychologist Donald E. Super in 1955 based on his interest in describing the development of behaviors related to professional choice. Super's arguments, in the process of elaborating his theory, were related to criticisms of the prevailing conception of vocational choice of his time, which focused on similarities and differences between occupations and individuals (Lobato, 2001). Balbinotti (2003) indicates that Super defined vocational maturity as follows:

[...] the capacity of the individual to face the developmental tasks with which he is confronted as a consequence of his social and biological development, on the one hand, and the needs of society in relation to other people who reach this stage of development, on the other hand. (Balbinotti, 2003: 463).

Starting from the theory developed by Super, in which he elaborates a conception of the development of professional choice, there are stages through which the individual would pass during his vocational development, ranging from childhood to old age: growth, exploration, establishment, maintenance and withdrawal. By proposing these stages for vocational development, Super also elaborated a set of evolutionary tasks that the individual must successfully confront to progress to the next stage. These tasks linked mainly to the exploration and establishment stages are the following: a) crystallization of a vocational preference; b) specification of a vocational preference; c) implementation of a vocational preference; d) stabilization in a vocation; and e) consolidation and progression in a vocation.

Maturity for vocational choice is not exclusively linked to age but to the need to make a certain type of decision linked to the professional world throughout life. In general, this choice occurs more frequently in adolescence. To make a career choice that is close to one's interests and education level, young people must have accumulated information about themselves and their environment.

According to Super (1963 cited by Lobato, 2001: 16), the formation of self-concept begins in childhood, when the individual begins to develop his sense of identity, starting to see himself as a distinct person and, at the same time, like other people. In occupational terms, the self-concept begins to develop when the child/adolescent, from observation, identifies with adult models or even when they experience roles in which they learn that certain attributes are suitable for certain occupations.

This process can occur in different ways, such as a) identification with the adult can lead to the desire to play the same occupational role as the adult; b) experiencing roles, which can lead the individual to develop their occupational self-concept in an adequate or unexpected way; and c) knowing personal attributes and being aware that they are important in a particular field of work. The way an individual reacted in the past, formulating his conception of the world, influences his future and the choice of an occupation, being part of it.

As people are different in terms of their self-concept, they also differ in the way they translate them into occupational terms. Understanding the ways in which self-concept develops helps to understand how people choose different occupations and how the same person may have an interest in various occupations.

■ GENDER ISSUES INVOLVED IN PROFESSIONAL CHOICE

Peculiar or stereotyped characteristics of men and women are built throughout changes in social life and exert a strong influence on people's lives. Lassance and Magalhães (2004) and Louro (2007) indicate that dealing with gender issues implies intertwining natural categories such as sex, ethnicity and generations with categories impregnated with meanings such as politics, culture, and ideologies, inevitably distributed in terms of hierarchies, privileges and inequalities.

Through a process of internalization, the individual apprehends a data as significant for him, assuming the world in which others live, until there is a mutual identification between him and the others. The first socialization, called primary socialization, takes place through the process of identification with significant others, who mediate the world for the individual. Thus, what makes the human being a member of society is the process of socialization.

Social groups are organized by the typifications and role performance of their members. As stated by Lassance and Magalhães (2004), it is the social roles that locate individuals

in terms of self-experience and within society. The act of performing a certain action contained in the definition of a certain role allows a person to understand a part of their personality through the validity given to the social role.

Our culture and many others define a series of interests, personal attributes and behaviors as “feminine” or “masculine”. Children learn and adopt many of these standards imposed early on (Louro, 2007). The psychological variable “gender” refers to the characteristics that human beings develop and internalize in response to social expectations regarding them and their biological sex. The term gender identity refers to the possibility of masculinity and femininity in the performance of social roles, meaning that both dimensions are found in all people but in different ways and degrees (Louro, 2007). As stated by Stoller (1993, p. 61):

Although masculinity matches the quality of being a man and femininity the quality of being a woman, sex and gender are not necessarily related. Masculinity or femininity are defined as qualities that are felt by those who possess them as masculine or feminine. In addition to the biological foundation, the person derives these convictions from the attitudes of the parents, especially in childhood, and these attitudes are more or less similar to those held by society as a whole, filtered by the idiosyncratic personality of the parents. Therefore, such convictions are not eternal truths: they change when societies change (Stoller, 1993: 61).

Louro (2007) and Ribeiro (2006) indicate that masculinity and femininity are defined not only by biologically determined sex but also by activities of interest, such as playing with dolls or strollers, personality traits (being sensitive or independent) and gender-based relationships (playing with boys or girls). A woman may love kitchens and have an interest in auto mechanics; a man can be both independent and affectionate and sensitive. In each case, the person’s basic gender identity as female or male remains more stable.

According to Ribeiro (2006), the differences created or socially attributed according to the genders suffer variations according to the structure and historical-cultural characterization of what would constitute the world of men and women. In structural terms, according to a study on boys’ and girls’ play carried out by Ribeiro (2006), relationships in Brazilian society still limit many women to the exclusive universe of home and reproduction due to lack of options in the labor market, low education and little (or almost no) diversification in the qualification of the workforce.

Ribeiro (2006) also highlights in his study the children’s cultural universe and gender issues, where he reveals that in everyday interactions in the children’s environment, social actors present classifications that meet the ideal types in the definition of what is the appropriate and expected behavior of children. boys and girls. They reproduce the information transmitted by adults, re-elaborate and create ideas about the way of acting of the people with whom they dialog and live, starting a cycle in which the most sophisticated social constructions about sex

and gender emerge under symbolic forms of gestures, ways of walking, sitting and talking, and body eroticization games. According to the study, the author concludes the following:

Among the children themselves, therefore, being a man and being a woman is related not only to the anatomical-physiological apparatus but also to social conceptions, many of which are learned in the family and in the system of relationships in which they live. The category man and woman, in this case, boy and girl, involves social and symbolic attributes, such as being able to do certain things, legitimately exercising sexuality, and assuming behaviors within a certain order (Ribeiro, 2006: 168).

Louro (2007) highlights that the construction of gender identity occurs within the scope of culture and history, where not only sexual or gender identities but also ethnic, nationality, class identities are defined. This way:

[...] these multiple identities can demand, at the same time, distinct, divergent or even contradictory loyalties. We are subjects of many identities. These multiple social identities can also be provisionally attractive and then seem disposable to us; they can then be rejected and abandoned. We are subjects of transient and contingent identities. Therefore, sexual and gender identities (like all social identities) have a fragmented, unstable, historical and plural character, affirmed by cultural theorists and theorists (Louro, 2007: 12).

■ THE FORMATION OF PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY AND ITS RELATION TO GENDER IDENTITY

In recent years, society in general has become increasingly aware of differences and the multiplicity of social roles that exist in it. The changes resulting from this process of awareness can be seen from the development of concepts and theories that begin to give new interpretations to reality.

Despite these transformations, there are interpretations that are resistant to time and present in different cultures. From an early age, for example, people learn and transmit different concepts, such as that girls need to be docile and boys need to be assertive. School education itself, in most cases, reinforces these differences in the form of sexist stereotypes (Lassance & Magalhães, 2004; Ribeiro, 2006; Louro, 2007; Belo, Sousa & Camino, 2008).

Studies carried out by Belo, Souza and Camino (2008) to observe the characterization of professions in male and female formats/poles indicated that professions related to the male universe are generally associated with gains and recognition of assertiveness and material success. In the case of women, the data found corroborate the literature, which associates the feminine with submission and care, evidencing professions such as maids, nurses, secretaries, manicurists and pedagogues.

Lassance and Magalhães (2004) indicate that the self-concept is translated into vocational terms in adolescence, and therefore, the quality of information that the individual has about himself and the job market becomes essential, as distortions or false or incomplete information can lead to wrong choices. The translation of the self-concept into vocational terms depends on how the individual interprets their qualities, aptitudes and characteristics, also taking into account gender issues.

Turning attention to gender issues involved in the formation of professional self-concept is essential to promote a reflection on gender inequalities. Such disparities can be observed to the extent that women, in general, are still socialized, reinforcing attributes such as honesty, care, submission, docility and great capacity for giving, as well as being encouraged to demonstrate skills such as the verbal expression of feelings. According to Lobato (2001):

It is well known that the male x female dichotomy is embedded in the traditions of almost all cultures. Societies build gender stereotypes that appear both in the behavior of subjects and in their cognitive evaluations of themselves and others, according to these categories. In this sense, the current conception of the gender theoretical construct is part of the current of cognitive social psychology (Lobato, 2001: 32-33).

This process of social production of genres made the behaviors valued in the world of work limited to the masculine order, that is, characteristics oriented toward competence, self-affirmation, achievement, independence, experience and curiosity. This same group of behaviors reveals the need to be competitive, rational, opportunistic, individualistic, and autonomous, characteristics that are always discouraged in girls and women. In view of the above, we will present below some brief considerations about a study, still in progress, that seeks to understand the maturity for the professional choice of young people, taking into account the problem of gender.

■ METHODOLOGIC PROCEDURES

The present study is configured as descriptive research with a qualitative approach, being carried out in schools of the public and private education systems located in the state of Minas Gerais/Brazil. For data collection in this study, the Maturity Scale for Professional Choice - EMEP (Neiva, 1999) and a questionnaire - developed exclusively for this research - with open and closed questions that addressed aspects related to professional choice, influence on professional choice, expectations for the future, gender, knowledge of the reality of the job market, sources of information about professions and self-knowledge.

Students, whose age range is between 16 and 18 years old, were invited to take part in the research, with no obligation to participate. After explanations to the participants, the

questionnaire was applied collectively in the classroom, and the duration of the application varied between 15 and 25 minutes.

■ RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Qualitative analysis procedures were used to interpret the results, as they are more suitable for identifying and understanding the social events discussed here (Gomes, 1994). Following the data identified in the EMEP, the following categories were investigated: A) attitude toward professional choice (which includes the subcategories determination, responsibility, and independence) and B) knowledge necessary for professional choice (formed by the subcategories self-knowledge of the subject and knowledge of reality in which it is inserted - including the professional reality).

In the comparison according to the gender of the participants, when considering the general/global level of maturity for the professional choice, the adolescents surveyed presented results within the middle and upper middle levels, without differentiation by gender. Gender differences were also not evidenced in the subdimensions referring to self-knowledge and determination to choose a profession. However, the results showed that there is a significant difference in maturity according to the respondent's gender in the other subdimensions.

Regarding the attitudes toward the adolescents' professional choice (including the subcategories responsibility and independence), according to the data obtained in the questionnaire and in the application of the EMEP, the female participants were more responsible and independent, since they reported suffering less influence from the opinion of other people to make this decision, indicating greater autonomy and responsibility in their professional choice process.

In aspects related to the knowledge necessary for professional choice, male adolescents showed greater knowledge of the educational, economic and labor/occupational market reality. At this point, it should be noted that both male and female youth stressed that the current choice is not completely "closed", showing flexibility for changes.

Ribeiro (2006) emphasizes that gender patterns are established from childhood and are largely constructed by expectations of parents/family members and the culture, where the roles expected for men and women are associated with socially constructed characteristics as feminine or male. This is later reflected in adolescence and career choice, when patterns of behavior and social acceptance influence the occupational role that boys and girls must follow or fulfill for their lives as adults.

Thus, the fact that, in this study, female adolescents show themselves to be more responsible is related to the care expectations that, in adulthood, women assume when playing the role of mother/caregiver, associated with private spaces. In the same way, the results

that indicate a greater concern of the male participants with the economic reality and with the world of work evidence the appreciation of the occupation of the male in public spaces and in the performance of roles of provider, leader etc. (Louro, 2007).

■ FINAL CONSIDERATIONS

Social production on gender stereotypes leads to a standardization of the way male or female individuals should behave and place themselves in the world, including the construction of professional identity and self-concept. However, it is important to emphasize that these “naturalized” patterns are historical constructions that legitimize inequalities insofar as they privilege the masculine to the detriment of the feminine.

In this sense, reflections on gender issues involved in professional choice should serve as subsidies for the construction of more effective interventions committed to social changes. Professional guidance, as a social and professional practice and a product of human relationships, should not be exercised as an activity unlinked from the ethical and political dimensions that permeate society, which implies adopting, among other commitments, the search for equality between genders in society said practice.

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